



(LEFT TO RIGHT) SEVEN-YEAR-OLD RAHMAN ON HIS FATHER'S KEYBOARD; WITH HIS MOTHER AND SISTERS; WITH ROOTS, A ROCK BAND HE PLAYED WITH AND WITH WIFE SAIRA

couches in both his home and commercial studios are proof that sometimes the waiting directors do wilt and just crash out.

Stories about his late nights are legendary though director Rajiv Menon says it is simple. "I once asked him, why don't you work in the day? He said he would, "only the sunlight hurts his eyes." More precisely, says Menon, it probably echoes his apprentice years, when he would play in various orchestras in the day and compose advertising jingles during the night. It's when he made lasting friendships, from percussionist Sivamani to his CEO Selvakumar. It's also the time he played in five rock bands.

Everything changed when Mani Ratnam asked him to compose the soundtrack of *Roja*. The 1992 film was as controversial as its music was outstanding. For Rahman, every achievement since pales in comparison. It ricocheted him into a league of his own, an exclusivity that was further enhanced when Ram Gopal Varma asked him to compose the soundtrack for *Rangeela* in 1995. Over the years, Rahman has tried to work only with people he understands. From Ashutosh Gowariker to Aamir Khan, Subhash Ghai to Shankar, Mani Ratnam to Shyam Benegal, he works where there is a relationship. "I only work associate people I want to work with. The energy has to be right," he says. "It's almost like a friendship. It can't be that they commission me and I give the music and they go." As Gowariker says: "Rahman really blossoms when he is given more information about the script, the song, the characters, the settings. Whenever I complete a script, my

first phone call is to him."

But make no mistake. Rahman is no solemn proto-philosopher trapped in the ivory tower of his soaring creativity. He keeps an open house, with his private studio and meeting rooms on the ground floor, his mother on the first floor and his family on the second floor. His wife Saira is a shy, retiring sort but his three children, Katheeja, 12, Raheema, 10, and Rumi, 5, more than make up with their boisterous natures, playing noisily next to their father's reluctant fancy buy, a BMW 5 Series. "For many years," grumbles Selvakumar, "he was very happy to be driven around in an Ambassador. I had to force him to buy this." Hot idlis (or tiffin, as his oldest retainer Swami Durai says to all hungry visitors) are always on offer as is coffee on tap from two machines. "For the first two weeks of our arrival in India," says American Joshua Pollock, one of eight westerners who teach music at the KM Music Conservatory, "he even fed us every meal every day."

“ Music is such a beautiful profession. If you do it right, be clean. But it can also lead you to destruction since you are vulnerable to everything. ”

If making music is his primary talent, his ability to spot talent is not far behind. Whether it is in choosing the faculty for his school or the singers for his soundtracks, Rahman has an unerring eye. It's not just that he has built a voice bank from all over the world categorised according to their genres. But it is also that he listens, choosing Rashid Ali, a guitarist he heard at a concert for the Gujarat earthquake in London, to sing the soulful *Kabhi kabhi Aditi* in *Jaane Tu... Ya Jaane Na*, or Kavita Baliga who teaches Western vocals at the conservatory and found her way into *Guzarish* in *Ghajini*. There are mo-